

GLOBAL
EDITION



Marketing Research

An Applied Orientation

SEVENTH EDITION

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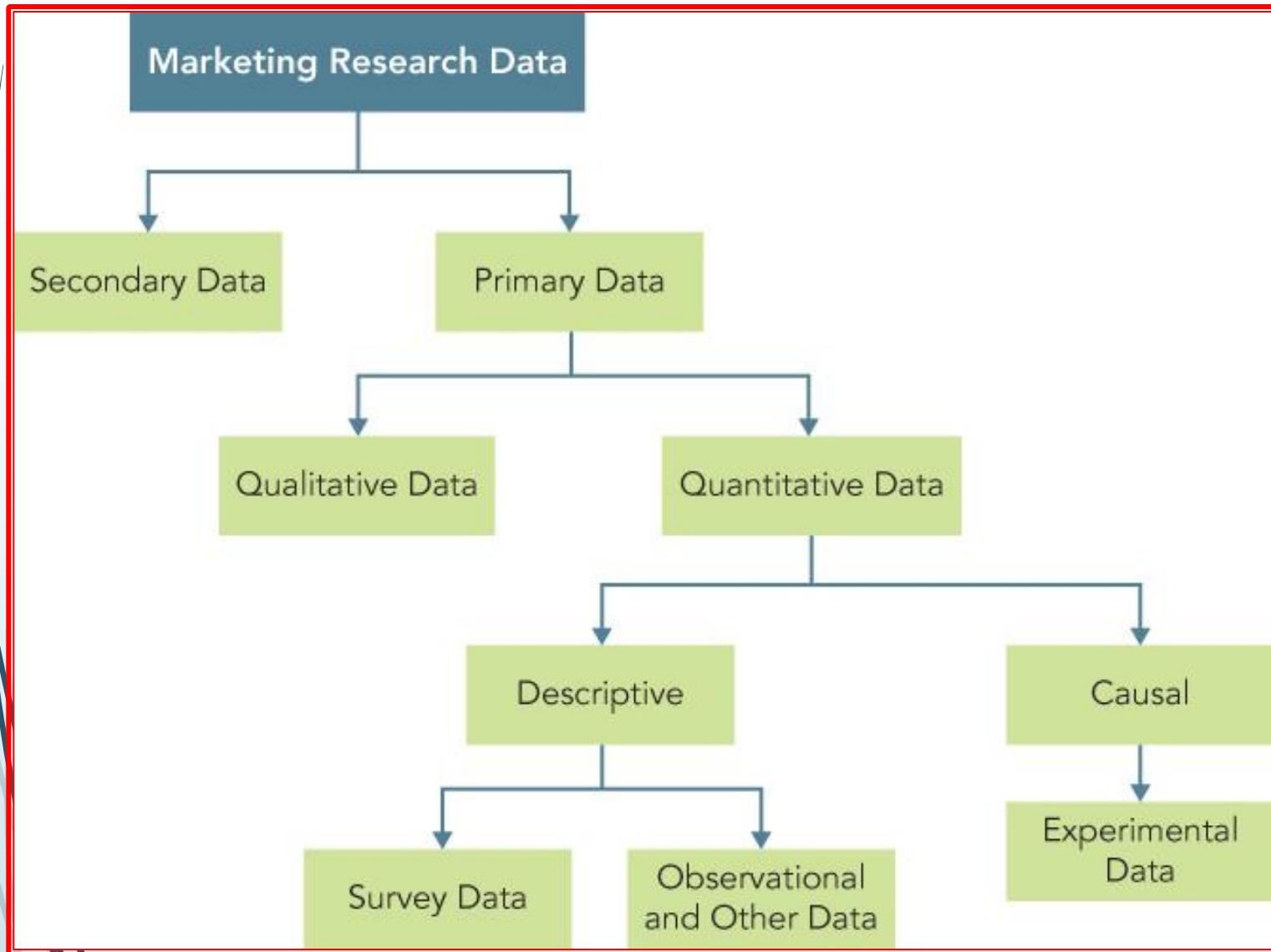
Chapter 5:

Exploratory Research Design: Qualitative Research

Classification of Marketing Research Data



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Qualitative Versus Quantitative Research



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Qualitative Research

Quantitative Research

Objective

To gain a qualitative understanding of the underlying reasons and motivations

To quantify the data and generalize the results from the sample to the population of interest

Sample

Small number of non-representative cases

Large number of representative cases

Data Collection

Unstructured

Structured

Data Analysis

Non-statistical

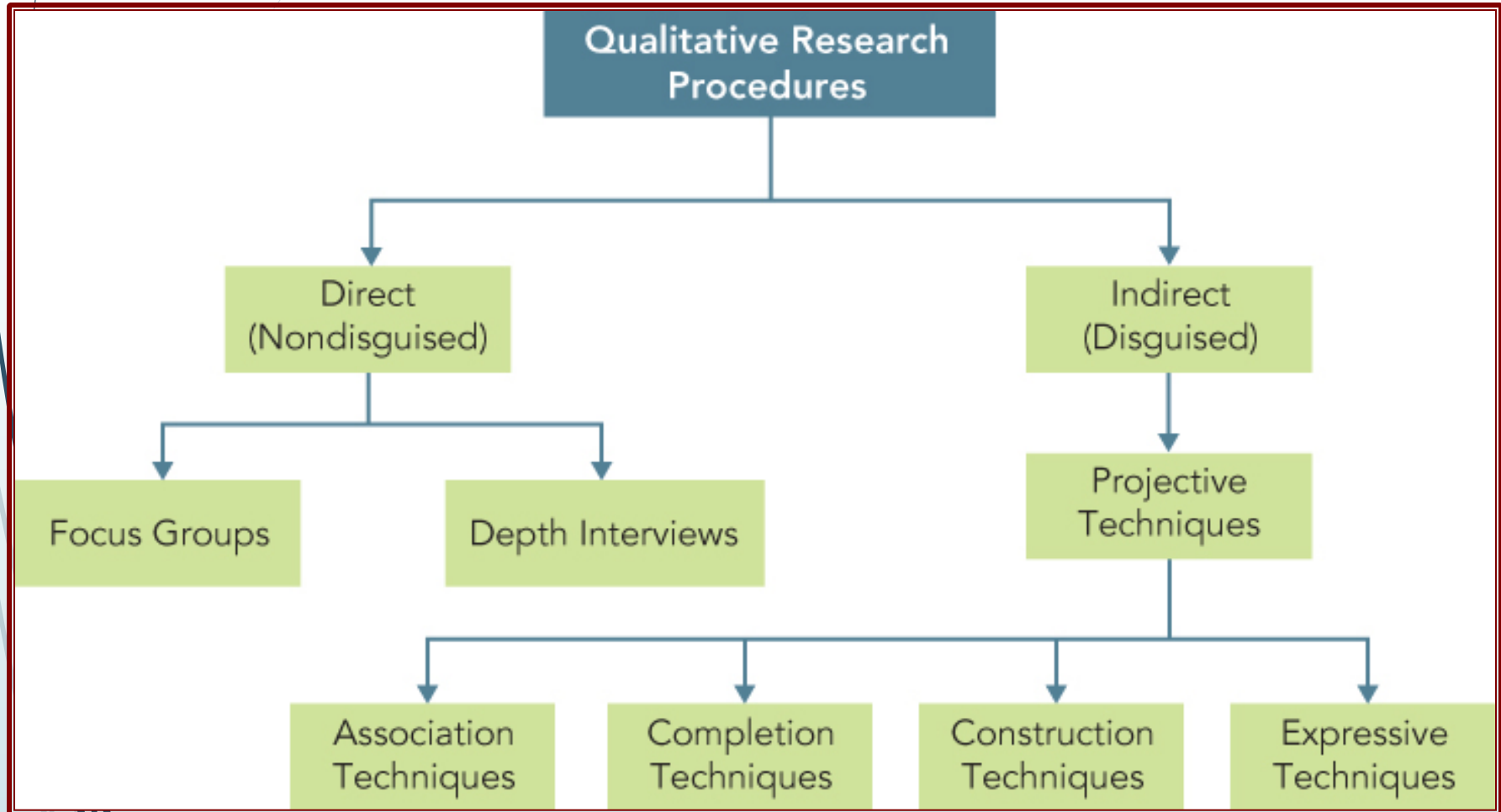
Statistical

Outcome

Develop an initial understanding

Recommend a final course of action

Classification of Qualitative Research Procedures



(1) Focus Groups



Focus Group Discussions

- A Focus Group is an interview conducted by a trained moderator in an unstructured and natural manner with a small group of respondents. **Number of focus groups that should be conducted depends on: 1) nature of problem, 2) time & cost.**
- The main purpose of focus groups is to gain insights by listening to a group of people from the target population.
- **The value of this technique lies in the unexpected findings often obtained from a free-floating group discussion.**

Focus groups are so popular that many practitioners consider this technique synonymous with qualitative research

Rules of Focus Group Discussions

- **Prepare for several focus groups.** There may be variation between groups, but an individual group must be comprised of similar types of people. **Participants are screened for verbal ability, experience and willingness to be candid about their opinions.**
- **Setting is important.** Many firms use central facilities with one-way mirrors and sophisticated electronic recording equipment. Hotel halls and other meeting facilities can be quite acceptable venues for a focus group especially for the professional and business community.
- **Major issues are reviewed prior to the group.** The moderator should prepare the **agenda** (also termed a "**protocol**") which will guide the group discussion.
- **Focus groups are usually Video/Audio-taped.** Under no circumstances should this be kept secret; participants must be informed both of the recording devices and that they are being observed. Anyone who is uncomfortable may leave.

Viewing Room Looking into the Focus Group Room Through One-Way Mirror



Characteristics of Focus Groups

Group Size	8-12
Group Composition	Homogeneous, and respondents prescreening
Physical setting	Relaxed, informal atmosphere Questions flow from general to specific
Time duration	1-3 hours
Recording	Use of audiocassettes and videotapes
Moderator	Observational, interpersonal, and communication skills of the moderator

Key Qualifications of Focus Group Moderator

1. **Kindness with firmness:** The moderator must combine a disciplined detachment with understanding empathy so as to generate the necessary interaction.
2. **Permissiveness:** The moderator must be permissive yet alert to signs that the group's cordiality or purpose is disintegrating.
3. **Involvement:** The moderator must encourage and stimulate intense personal involvement.
4. **Incomplete understanding:** The moderator must encourage respondents to be more specific about generalized comments by exhibiting incomplete understanding.

Key Qualifications of Focus Group Moderator, Cont.

5. **Encouragement:** The moderator must encourage unresponsive members to participate.
6. **Flexibility:** The moderator must be able to improvise and alter the planned outline amid the distractions of the group process.
7. **Sensitivity:** The moderator must be sensitive enough to guide the group discussion at an intellectual as well as emotional level.

Most Importantly A “Big Picture” Thinker

Elements of Success of Focus Groups

Group dynamics/conflicts are critical. The meeting must be positive and lead to easy interaction on the part of group members.

Homogenous group composition is the norm. It is usually unproductive to combine young and old, or junior and senior in the same group unless they are united by a strong common interest. The comfort level respondents have with each other is extremely important to gaining useful information.

Moderator skill is very important. It requires maturity, research experience, and substantive knowledge of the field.

A clear agenda for the group discussion is essential. The topic must be familiar to all participants with the agenda consisting of 5 – 10 main issues. A common mistake is to "load" the agenda with a detailed set of questions which need to be explored. When participants are rushed, they will not provide in-depth reactions. For example, in a two hour (120 minute) focus group of 12 participants with 20 issues, each has 30 seconds on average to react to each issue.

Problems in Group Dynamics

Tolerate silence. It is important to respect the need for individuals to collect their thoughts. If you have spent time explaining why their thoughtful opinions are important to the research, why rush them for information?

Enlist the aid of dominant participants. Ask another person to react to the dominant participant's comment. In this way, others have the opportunity to enter the discussion. Drawing out those who are reluctant to speak is the mark of a skilled moderator (i.e. ensure that everyone speaks).

Conflict is an indicator of mixed opinions on the issue. Exploring these differences is important. Of course, personality conflicts among group members are unproductive and mediation skills are another indicator of a good moderator.

A minimum number of groups are needed if the population is low diverse. Fewer sessions may be conducted if the range of issues is slight and if variation within the population is expected to be low.

Variations in Focus Groups

- **Two-way focus group.** This allows one target group to listen to and learn from a related group. For example, a focus group of physicians viewed a focus group of arthritis patients discussing the treatment they desired.
- **Dual-moderator group.** A focus group conducted by two moderators: One moderator is responsible for the smooth flow of the session, and the other ensures that specific issues are discussed.
- **Dueling-moderator group.** There are two moderators, but they deliberately take opposite positions on the issues to be discussed.
- **Online focus groups.** Focus groups conducted online over the Internet.

Online Vs Traditional Focus Groups

Characteristic	Online Focus Groups	Traditional Focus Groups
Group size	4 to 6 participants	8 to 12 participants
Group composition	Anywhere in the world	Drawn from the local area
Time duration	1 to 1.5 hours	1 to 3 hours
Physical setting	Researcher has little control	Under the control of the researcher
Respondent identity	Difficult to verify	Can be easily verified
Respondent attentiveness	Respondents can engage in other tasks	Attentiveness can be monitored
Respondent recruiting	Easier. Can be recruited online, by email, by panel, or by traditional means	Recruited by traditional means (telephone, mail, mail panel)
Group dynamics	Limited	Synergistic, snowballing (bandwagon) effect

Online Vs Traditional Focus Groups, Cont.

Characteristic	Online Focus Groups	Traditional Focus Groups
Openness of respondents	Respondents are more candid due to lack of face-to-face contact	Respondents are candid, except for sensitive topics
Nonverbal communication	Body language cannot be observed Emotions expressed by using symbols	Easy to observe body language and emotions
Use of physical stimuli	Limited to those that can be displayed on the Internet	A variety of stimuli (products, advertising, demonstrations, and so on) can be used
Transcripts	Available immediately	Time-consuming and expensive to obtain
Observers' communication with moderator	Observers can communicate with the moderator on a split-screen	Observers can manually send notes to the focus-group room

Online Vs Traditional Focus Groups, Cont.

Characteristic	Online Focus Groups	Traditional Focus Groups
Unique moderator skills	Typing, computer usage, familiarity with chat-room slang	Observational
Turnaround time	Can be set up and completed in a few days	Takes many days for setup and completion
Client travel costs	None	Can be expensive
Client involvement	Limited	High
Basic focus-group costs	Much less expensive	More expensive due to facility rental, food, video/audio taping, and transcript preparation